"Learning never exhausts the mind."
Leonardo da Vinci

ACADEMIC WRITING:
Academic Style I

Developed and compiled by
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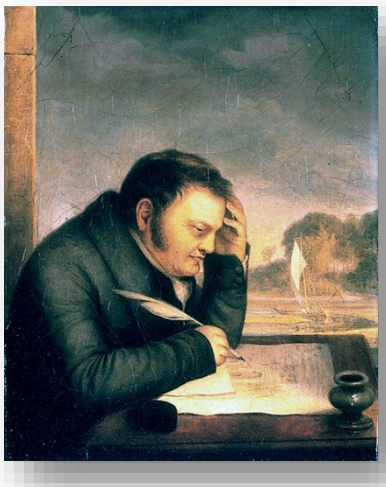
PART 1: ACADEMIC WRITING STYLE REVIEW

Informal / Formal Vocabulary



1. You should usually avoid spoken, colloquial or idiomatic language. **Which of the following are unsuitable in academic writing?**

get	a lot/lots of	thing	big
actually	nowadays	as we all know	all in all
such as	many	for instance	considerable
factor	issue	besides	good/bad
think	last but not least		every coin has two sides

2. Find formal equivalents in the box (words or expressions) for the informal vocabulary in the sentences below. Each word in the box is used only once. **There may be more than one word per sentence:**

growing; highly; several; unpleasant; detrimental; excel; receives; point; consider; significant; surprisingly;

Example:

Maybe = *perhaps* the Dutch or the English were the first to trade brandy with Amerindians (one word).

a) Bad weather in the UK increased demand for holidays abroad. = ……..

b) Most of those who smoke know that it is really bad for health. = ……

c) Amazingly, Switzerland gets more US investment than all of South America. = ……..…...….....

d) There is another thing to think about here. = …….……

e) Shopping centres bring big increases in traffic. = …….

f) Getting old can be seen as a natural and gradual process. = ……

g) Lots of students declared that they were not good at sport. = ……

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GUIDELINES FOR ACADEMIC WRITING STYLE

1. Read the guidelines for academic writing style below and complete the information. **You may need to look at a) the example(s) in order to give the rule b) the rule in order to complete the example(s), or c) one part of a rule to complete another:**

Rules: Avoid ✘ Use ✓	Examples of poor academic style	Examples of good academic style
Avoid ✘ **1.** informal language **Use** ✓ appropriate academic (and discipline-specific) vocabulary and collocations	**a)** Students are offered a lot of opportunities to be involved in the community. **b)** In a nutshell, the evidence supports the argument in favour of introducing more marketplace competition into education.	**a)** Students are offered …….. opportunities to be involved in the community. **b)** ……., the evidence supports the argument in favour of introducing more marketplace competition into education.
Avoid ✘ **2.** …….. ✘ **Use** ✓ precise and detailed language	**a)** The report presents many things. **b)** For example, it permits people to clear the entire shopping cart with a single click.	**a)** The report presents many …….... **b)** For example, it permits shoppers to clear the entire shopping cart with a single click.
Avoid ✘ **3.** strong/exaggerated language or sweeping statements **Use** ✓ cautious language where appropriate	**a)** Science fiction writers always portray AI as robots with human-like characteristics. **b)** As we all know, there are many problems to be solved in healthcare. **c)** Our children's healthcare is a total priority.	**a)** Science fiction writers …… …… portray AI as robots with human-like characteristics. **b)** It is …… that there are many problems to be solved in healthcare. **c)** Children's healthcare should be considered a priority.
Avoid ✘ **4.** expressions that …….... ……..……✘ **Use** ✓ statements that do not contain such expressions	In my opinion, drinking more than two cups of coffee per day is harmful to health.	Drinking more than two cups of coffee per day can be harmful to health.

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ACADEMIC STYLE		
Avoid ✗ **5.** ……..., such as: *I*, *me*, *you*, *he*, *she*, *him*, *her*, *we*, and *us*; in particular, you should avoid referring to yourself or the reader ✗ **Use** ✓ full nouns where appropriate; you should also be impersonal - this can often be achieved by using the *passive form*	**a)** This could help us to achieve higher scores in the exam. **b)** We have discovered that AI will accomplish any intellectual task a human being can by the year 2050	**a)** This could help students to achieve higher scores in the exam. **b)** …… that AI will accomplish any intellectual task a human being can by the year 2050
Avoid ✗ **6.** contractions or abbreviations ✗ **Use** ✓ full words You may use abbreviations for phrases that appear three or more times in a paper. When you first use a phrase that can be abbreviated, spell it out in full and show the abbreviation in parentheses immediately afterwards.	**a)** It's beneficial to the community. **b)** This requirement must be completed a.s.a.p.	**a)** It …….. beneficial to the community. **b)** This requirement must be completed ……...…….. **c)** The study was conducted at the University of Lagos (UNILAG). Many UNILAG students were surveyed for this research.
Avoid ✗ **7.** …….……. **Use** ✓ statements instead	What are the main benefits of physical activity?	The main benefits of physical activity include enhanced mood and increased physical stamina.
Avoid ✗ **8.** exclamations **Use** ✓ a statement with particular constructions, for example: **a)** the passive **b)** the *-ing* form of the verb **c)** language for recommendations (eg or **d)** an if-clause	**a-d)** Plant trees to improve air quality!	**a)** To improve air quality more trees should be planted. **b)** ……..…. more trees can improve air quality. **c)** One suggestion is to plant more trees to improve air quality. **d)** ……..., the air quality is likely to improve.

e) If you include ideas that are not your own you must give a citation.	**e)** In 2020, Peter Johnson said we must plant more trees!	**e)** …….. the planting of more trees can lead to improved air quality.
Avoid ✘ **9.** using ……., ……. , or …… at the beginning of a sentence **Use** ✓ one of the following options instead: **a)** connect the sentence with the previous sentence *or* **b)** use a more formal linking word/phrase	**a)** And the corporation is currently involved in numerous projects to alleviate the housing needs of the nation. **b)** Until the eighth century BC, there are no written records. But after the seventh century BC, literary remains start to appear. **c)** Some students may not see the point of working hard; so, they make less effort.	**a)** ……., the corporation is currently involved in numerous projects to alleviate the housing needs of the nation. **b)** Until the eighth century BC, there are no written records. ……..., after the seventh century BC, literary remains start to appear. **c)** Some students may not see the point of working hard; ……, they make less effort.
Avoid ✘ **10.** Using …….…… language **Use** ✓ neutral language where possible	**a)** The residue from the experiment was a beautiful red colour. **b)** Amazingly, Einstein failed to meet the minimum admission requirements for Zurich Polytechnic.	**a)** The residue from the experiment was red in colour. **b)** ……. Einstein failed to meet the minimum admission requirements for Zurich Polytechnic.
Avoid ✘ **11.** Many phrasal verbs **Use** ✓ appropriate academic (and discipline-specific) vocabulary and collocations	**a)** Three individuals took part in each session of the experiment. **b)** Important data were left out of the analysis	**a)** Three individuals participated in each session of the experiment. **b)** Important data were ……. from the analysis

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PHRASAL VERBS

1. Match the phrasal verbs below with their formal, academic equivalents:

BOX 1

1. Ascertain
2. devise
3. discard
4. emit
5. progress
6. discuss
7. consider
8. repeat
9. return
10. tolerate

BOX 2

a) give out
b) come back
c) talk about
d) think up
e) put up with
f) carry on
g) do again
h) throw away
i) find out
j) look at

1. Complete each sentence with a suitable academic word from Box 1; **be careful to give the correct tense and form:**

a) This essay will *discuss* = ~~talk about~~ the effects of early schooling on academic performance.

b) …….. racism would be incompatible with Kant's basic principle of respect for humanity in each person.

c) The political establishment seems unable to ……. new strategies for economic development.

d) Energy ……. by a star is generated by nuclear fusion.

e) The Romans left Britain in 383 and never ……..

f) The experiments are……. in order to verify the accuracy of the findings.

g) Plastic ……. by humanity is accumulating in the oceans.

h) It is sometimes necessary to …….the types of bacteria that are present.

i) Global warming is ……. at a speed that far exceeds most forecasts.

j) These authors also ……. other theories of gravity.

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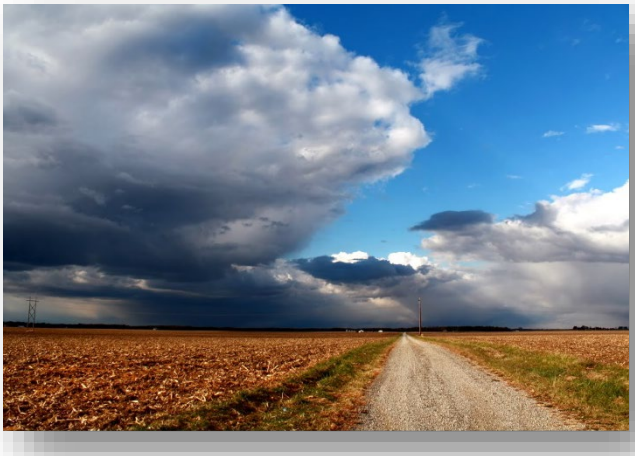
AMENDING ERRORS OF ACADEMIC STYLE

1. Amend the examples of poor academic style in the following sentences. **Areas where vocabulary is not appropriate are indicated in blue italics:**

Example:

- Carbon dioxide is *given off* by the natural processes of decay in plants.

- Carbon dioxide is emitted by the natural processes of decay in plants.



a) As *we* predicted , children who possess more empathy show less aggressive behaviour.

……..

b) Carbon dioxide is *given off* by the natural processes of decay in plants.

……..

c) In this essay*, I* will outline three of the underlying causes of undernutrition: conflict, poverty and disease.

……..……

……

d) The weather *got worse and worse* as the evening *went on*.

……..……

……

……

e) Retirement is something almost all of *us* must face sooner or later.

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……

……

f) Based on *our* results*, I feel* that there is a need for university libraries to better adapt to students' needs.

……

……

g) *Last but not least, lots of people think* that streaming students by ability is *good* for learning.

……

……

h) Cloning *lets us* create a new person with the genetic material of just one parent.

……

……

i) The engineer consulted with the team in order to *come up with* a new solution to the problem.

……

……

j) Sustainability is *a big hot potato* in the fashion world *right now*.

……

……

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